Kong

By Pamela Sneed

INTRODUCTION

Kong by Pamela Sneed tackles the current political landscape of war in Iraq, the crisis in New Orleans, the lack of American healthcare, gay and lesbian issues, and finally the need for new kinds of activism. Sneed's poem never loses sight of her aim: to offer a work that is transformative, intellectual, emotional, and spiritual. At its heart, Kong is a resilient protest work, and a luminescent and universal call for freedom. Kong by Pamela Sneed.

I want to talk about that last *Star Wars* movie which

they promised was a final installment

But we'll see

all I can say is it really sucked except for the part near

the end

where you see the transformation of Luke Skywalker

into the evil Darth Vader

His innocence destroyed

crawling through some molten lava-limbless

He looked like a soldier

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or something out of a war movie one of those battered

survivors

who has left his child self behind him

But, I earnestly believed

And now all I can do is carry myself/battle scarred to

some semblance of safety

All I can do is hold on like a survivor of the tsunami tidal

wave

Hold on to a tree, a pipe, anything, my papers from an

old life

verifying who I am

wait for the storm to pass

a shoulder to lean on/anything

But I earnestly believed.

You know when I left my parents house the small town

for a big city

and experienced all accoutrements of a counter culture

I earnestly believed

queer boys

queer nations

nose rings

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dread locks
muscle shirts on girls
punk rockers
were all some semblance of an alternative
I believed poet Glen James
who called us the sissified warriors
I believed when Marlon Riggs premiered the ground
breaking film for Black Gay Men, *Tongues Untied.*
I believed Audre Lorde when she said in synopsis if we
don't do our work
One day women's blood will congeal upon a dead planet.
I believed poet Assoto Saint in all 6ft 4 of his cross
dressing self
I believed when he stood up at the funeral of Donald
Woods
and said in essence we must tell the truth about who we
really are.
I believed Black lesbian writer Pat Parker when she
declared
straights are OK, but why must they be so blatant

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I earnestly believed when my child eyes almost twenty
years ago
first saw bisexual poet June Jordan
and the first thing she said was this country needs a
revolution.
I believed in Nelson and Winnie premiering even at the
height of apartheid with their fists
and heads held high
I believed even after they found Angel my student at
Hetrick Martin murdered
a handsome boy chopped into pieces
Yeah when they were still pulling queers out of the river
there downtown
Dead from queer bashings and suicide
I kept on believing change was possible.
I read the literature
had hope
I lived in America after all.
I earnestly believed.
You know this is an aside but

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I'm tired of the previews for that latest *King Kong* movie
Tired of all the actors looking to the sky with that same perplexed look,
That over the top awesome
because King Kong is computer generated they can't see him
so they're really acting
and you know King is a thin veil for a Black man
America assuaging it's racial fears.
Still, I'll pay ten, or twelve or twenty with popcorn to see it.
There was a time too when I earnestly believed in theatre
in performance
Believed I'd be a great big overnight success
that courage, innovation, tenacity would be recognized. I earnestly believed
And I know there are those who will say I'm bitter
mislabel me
say I spew hatred

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am raining down on their parade
That I lack optimism
when I try to say there is another America
when I try to say things are not equal
when I try telling them there are crimes being carried out with doctors
many of them are modern criminals
who don't deserve white coats
There's another final solution that's occurring right under our noses
and it's gonna get tougher and tougher
and tougher and tougher to hide the bodies
I earnestly believed
Saddam Hussein has been tried and convicted
but maybe it's just my secret silly wish
I keep wanting them to try George Bush
I keep wanting those feared 30,000 Iraqi soldiers dead
I want their bodies to rise up
walk to the White House
speak against this senseless war
For them to matter

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to someone besides their mothers
I want to see something like the truth and reconciliation
hearings after apartheid
where this country must admit to committing atrocities
I want those millions of Americans living without health care after working an entire lifetime ...
I want seniors who can't afford their prescriptions
I want my parents to go
I want America's poor
ones who know about when hospitals and doctors pull the plug on those who can't pay
I want the family of that little Black girl in New Orleans
whose body was found floating facedown
still wearing pink short shorts and a pink squeegee in hear hair.
Again, in New Orleans, I want the son whose mother died during the floods
waiting for governmental help,
I want everyone to see the eyes of my student,

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a black girl whose family is from the Ninth Ward in New Orleans and how she looked the day in class when she said
they won't give us back our houses
want everyone to hear my friend when she said Bush got up in the middle of the night to sign papers to help Terry Schivo but did nothing to help the people of New Orleans
I want every year for those gays and lesbians in New York during Gay Pride
to stop dancing on the piers and form a political movement I want all those voiceless people we're turning our
backs on
right now in the Darfur region of Africa to speak
And thank you Oprah, Thank you Bono, Thank you Jon Bon Jovi for your generous donations
but the system has to change
Yes, there was a time when I earnestly believed
People get so defensive when I try telling them what's happening systemically

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when I say under this regime censorship has increased.
Artists no longer have spaces to work
nor money
and it's not just all about personal will pulling oneself up
by a bootstrap
There is marginalization and silencing
occurring across the board more than in other eras
perhaps this is a return to.
I honestly believed once that there were people more
enlightened
that competition and jealousy couldn't destroy our
world.
I believed helping a neighbor was more important than
money
I earnestly believed
Yes, by now I'm probably like someone in a horror film
who gets killed off easy
wasn't careful enough
Kept running toward instead of away
from the monster
The one who stayed in haunted house

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you know who goes into an attic or a basement to
investigate what's going on
when they should have been long gone, the one who stays
in an abusive cycle
believes the partner will change
The one who hasn't read all the signals walks into a
thieves den
like on the old 42nd St.
with money hanging out of their pockets.
I earnestly believed like Anne Frank in human good.
I believed the slogans I read in kindergarten
that policemen help you across the street
will return lost children to their parents.
Maybe I'm as naive as MLK
when he said he had a dream of what America could
become
Maybe he isn't here to witness
just how tough things have become
Integration is now only a small step or small slice of
what we need.
Yesterday I sat down in the sun

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and let it beam across my face

I prayed like Martin Luther King I could live one day in

freedom

One day not racked by pain or injustice.

I felt like Harriet who lived in slavery

Just one day wanting to feel freedom's kiss

And caress.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier

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